

**JYOTIRADITYA M. SCINDIA,** *53* | BJP
*Minister of Communications*

**Call it in** With his massive win from family pocket borough Guna in Madhya Pradesh, Scindia has established his presence in the BJP, the party he switched to from the Congress in 2020. Son of the late Congress leader and Union minister Madhavrao Scindia, Jyotiraditya also heads the ministry for the Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER)

**Minister of State**



**CHANDRA SEKHAR PEMMASANI,** *48* | TDP

**Richie rich** A doctor by training, Pemmasani had declared assets of Rs 5,705 crore (the richest candidate in this election). The first-time MP won from Guntur in Andhra Pradesh

# DIALLING IN THE FUTURE

## Reviving BSNL and BharatNet, along with the rollout of the Telecom Act, top the to-do list

By M.G. ARUN

**In the past decade, the Indian telecom sector** has gone through a major transformation. From a competitive arena marked by several players, the sector has turned into a near-duopoly, dominated by Reliance Jio and Bharti Airtel. The previous telecom minister, Ashwini Vaishnaw, had overseen the expansion of the 5G rollout, which was aimed at enhancing user experience, and also negotiated the passing of the Telecommunications Act. Jyotiraditya Scindia, who gets the ministry in Modi 3.0, comes with much experience of handling high-profile ministries, both in the previous Modi government and with the UPA. The upcoming spectrum auction on June 25 will be a high priority area for him. ■

### WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

**RESURRECT BSNL** State-run BSNL reportedly lost 18 million subscribers in FY24 and has only 88.1 million customers as of March. The company's consolidated losses for Q3 of FY24 were Rs 1,569 crore. The Centre has already pumped in Rs 3.2 lakh crore through revival packages

**GO NORTHEAST** Connectivity in the north-eastern region is likely to get a push since Scindia is also minister for the Northeast region

**REVIVE BHARATNET** The BharatNet project, one of the world's biggest telecom projects to bring connectivity to rural areas, has been facing challenges since its rollout

**TELECOM ACT** The Telecommunications Act, 2023 will bring fundamental changes to regulatory protocols, including strict requirements for user authentication. It has also drawn flak for giving the government unbridled power to order internet shutdowns and for imperilling encryption